

Why do CEL?

What is community-engaged learning (CEL)?

Community-engaged learning (CEL) is a 'catch-all' term for a credit-bearing educational approach that combines meaningful engagement with communities and learning. The aim is to provide students with practical, 'real-world' experiential learning opportunities while they partner with communities to provide support and services or address societal needs.

You may have encountered many other related terms, such as Work-based learning, Live projects, Service-Learning, Authentic learning, and Community placements. These, for us, all form part of a family of practices. Common across these terms is an emphasis on knowledge as situational and context-driven, interpersonal, and filtered by emotional, cultural and political dimensions.



A draft definition for CEL:

"Community-engaged learning (**CEL**) is an educational approach that integrates meaningful community service with academic learning, personal growth, and civic responsibility. Also known as service learning, community-based learning, or community service, this pedagogical method goes beyond traditional classroom instruction by involving students in real-world, community-based projects."

What are some of the benefits?

Generally in higher education, we think the approach can bring multiple benefits to different partners, for example:

- For students, the approach can foster richer academic learning, skills development, personal growth and civic responsibility.
- For communities (whether local or international), it can help provide access to university resources, including contributing to research and helping them meet their organisational goals and objectives.
- For academics, it can help build bridges to community groups for research or knowledge exchange, provide meaning, deepen relationships with external groups, improve graduate outcomes, and help foster research-teaching links.



What motivates academics towards CEL?

Many motivations bring people to CEL. These might include:

- Alignment with how you see your discipline
- Wanting to provide students with real-world opportunities
- It is enjoyable and keeps you connected
- You want to 'give back'
- It connects your teaching with your research (e.g. if you are already doing engaged research)
- It leads you to places you never expected
- It challenges power structures
- It is aligned with your values

Exercise

Take a moment to think about or write down the following:

Institutional Strategy	Professional body accreditation	Employability and skills	Student experience	Civic and community	Personal motives
What are some of the levers for CEL that are embedded in your University Strategy or Education strategy?	How can CEL help meet the requirements of your accreditation board or professional body?	What is the contribution of CEL to developing student employability and skills?	Does CEL enrich the student experience? If so how? What might some of the drawbacks be?	What is the contribution of partners to your CEL programme? How might they benefit?	What are your drivers for this work? How does it relate to your research? What will keep you going?